Hidden in This Picture

By Aaron Sorkin

A small, grassy hill overlooking a massive expanse of land. ROBERT (the director) is surveying the scene before him. After a moment, REUBEN (the producer) enters. He's out of breath.

REUBEN: **(Pg 141-168)** The final shot, Robert, *one shot,* and then the crew, the cast, the six-hundred and ninety-four extras, the cameras, the lights, they all go home. There's no re-take. We can't ask the sun to come back and set again because we *messed* it up the first time. *(no response)* Three and a half minutes, Robert! Don't you think you should be down with the crew?

ROBERT: The crew knows what to do. *(He stops gazing out in the distance. He speaks directly to REUBEN)* We've been rehearsing for the past six hours. Despite the fact that this is my first film, a fact that you remind me of four times a day, I'm not an idiot. This is the most important shot in the movie, and I have no intention of *messing* it up. I have left absolutely no room for human error, Reuben. Six-hundred and ninety-four extras, already costumed and approved in their uniforms, will, in a slow, trickling theatrical stream, trot from the ridge of those trees, down past the blue flag and out of camera range. Roll credits. Together we're going to watch art being made. Jeff worked very hard on this screenplay.

REUBEN: Yeah? Well, it's lousy. I got news for you, if the audience doesn't understand what is going on, they leave. And they tell their friends. There's no sequel. And if you think I'm some kind of studio-puppet who only sees dollars and cents, you're right. That's my job.

INTRODUCTION

Do you know what makes a movie a movie? Think about it. A movie is pictures stitched together to make up 24 frames per second that give the illusion of motion. Photography brought to life to tell the story the artist (the director) wants to tell. It's beautiful, messy, and beyond fascinating. But today, the director has more to worry about that creating art. Production is 3 weeks behind and 6 million over budget. The sun is setting faster than it's ever set before, and the final long-angle sequence has to be filmed NOW, before the light fades.

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ROBERT: *(JEFF – the screenwriter enters)* Reuben's in a bad mood, Jeff. He thinks I've spent too much time and money making a movie about disillusioned Marines in Guam and he thinks your screenplay is full of Yale Drama crap.

JEFF: I'm not sure I'd say the Marines are disillusioned.

ROBERT: Jeff, I've created a picture here, I've communicated with an image -- an idea, an emotion, ***my*** idea, and I've done it as succinctly as a well written sentence and as powerfully as a symphony. The rest of this film may end up looking like Beaver Goes to War, but this shot is gonna work.

JEFF: Good luck.

ROBERT: Ssh! *(Pause, whispering)* Action. *(Pause)* Oh yeah. Oh. Oh my. This is for my children, Jeff. This is for my daughter, Jennifer, who'll watch it with her friends and say "My Daddy did that." This is for my unborn son who'll look at this and say, "I want to be just like my Dad." This isn't for the actors, Jeff; this one's for me. Look at it, Jeff, look at it.

JEFF: I'm looking . . . Bobby? *(Pause)* Three cows have walked into the shot.

ROBERT: *(Long pause. He must have heard wrong)* I'm sorry, what did you say?

JEFF: Three cows have walked into the shot.

ROBERT: *(ROBERT turns and looks out)* There are cows in the shot. Jesus Christ Almighty. *(He runs off yelling)* YOU'RE IN THE SHOT! GET OUT OF THE SHOT! COWS! GET THE HELL OUT OF THE SHOT! *(Long pause. ROBERT returns)* Before I even begin to try and solve this problem, I want you to tell me, Jeff, you wrote the screenplay, you did months of research, you read books, tell me, are there cows on Guam?

JEFF: Not on Marine bases.

ROBERT: Never?

JEFF: No, never. There are no cows on Marine bases. Anywhere. Guam, Nicaragua, Berlin, there are no cows.

ROBERT: Don't tell me there are no cows, there are three cows standing in the middle of the shot!

JEFF: That's because we're ten miles outside of Schenectady on a farm. We're only pretending

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we're on a Marine base. Bobby, it's okay. Just have some guys run out there and kinda shoo away the cows -- sorta herd 'em off to the left.

ROBERT: Jeff, an entire Marine infantry unit is running toward them with machine guns. They're not moving anywhere.

JEFF: It's 'cause they're all running past them. The cows probably can't even see them. Send some people out to run right towards them and herd 'em off. You can edit this stuff out and the scene'll be nine minutes instead of eleven minutes. *(Pause)* Bobby, it's the only thing to do.

ROBERT: Those cows have gotta be three-quarters of a mile away. We've got eight minutes left. Do you know how long it's gonna take to get a film crew to run three-quarters of a mile, clear the cows from the shot and then clear themselves from the shot? ***What are they doing there?*** *(CRAIG – Production assistant enters)*

CRAIG: Bobby, three cows have walked into the shot. I think it's pretty noticeable.

ROBERT: Oh? What makes you say that, Craig, what makes you say it's noticeable?

CRAIG: Well . . . everybody noticed.

JEFF: You might be able to salvage enough ending footage and then fudge around with the continuity on the sunset.

ROBERT: What's goin' on? God, why are you doing this to me? Please move the cows, God. Move 'em seventy-five yards to the left, God, what's the big deal? I'm not kidding, I'm really at a complete - I don't know what I'm supposed to do. Are you - Wait, wait, wait, what are they doing? They're bobbing their heads or something. What does that mean? Do you think that means they're ready to leave? Does it seem to you that they're about ready to leave?

CRAIG: I think they're about ready to leave.

JEFF: I don't - I'm not a livestock psychologist, Rob, I don't know if the cows seem ready to leave. Craig, on the other hand, has a very strong sense that the cows will be leaving soon.

ROBERT: Would you look at those guys? Just trotting by these cows like they weren't there. Doing it exactly the way we did it in rehearsal. You'd sorta think that one of 'em would say to himself "Hm, I'm an actor and I'm supposed to be imitating life. Right now I'm playing a Marine on my way back to the barracks. There's a cow. If I were a Marine, I'd probably think it was somewhat

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out of the ordinary to see a cow on my way back to my barracks." You'd think one of those guys would acknowledge the fact that they're running past three cows. . . *(Pause as Roberts surveys the scene)(Relieved)* The extras have discovered the cows. They're acting ***with*** the cows -- doing bits of business with the cows. I hate those cows! *(Beat)* You know what I think? It's not nearly as big a problem as we think it is.

JEFF: Truly, Robert, that's the attitude you gotta have.

ROBERT: I don't think anyone in the audience is gonna notice. I mean, sure, they're gonna notice, they're gonna see these three cows in silhouette against a sunset while 694 Marines file back to their barracks after having spent the most difficult day of their lives engaged in a war game, sure the audience is gonna see these cows, *but I don't think they're gonna find that strange.* Why should they? They're just cows. Everybody's seen cows.

JEFF: On a Marine compound? In Guam?

ROBERT: You think people are gonna pick that out? *(Makes up his mind)* Craig, call down to the deck. Get one of the policemen to shoot the cows.

JEFF: Craig, stop. Bobby, you can't tell the police to shoot the cows. You can't kill cows to make a movie.

ROBERT: We kill cows to make hamburgers, why can't I kill cows to make a movie, what's the difference?

JEFF: What's the difference between food and a movie? Are you serious?

ROBERT: They don't have to kill the cows, they don't have to shoot to kill, just drop 'em. Wound 'em for crying out loud, I'm running out of time.

JEFF: Bobby, allow me a very quick hypothetical. Let's assume for a moment that Schenectady police officers carry pistols that can fire three-quarters of a mile and that the officers are accurate at that range to be able to wound and not kill a cow. Fast forward a year. Don't you think that even the people who ***don't*** find it a little strange that three cows have wandered into Guam are gonna be a little perplexed when the cows, for no apparent reason, fall down to the ground?

ROBERT: You're right. I've been looking at this all wrong. Look at the cows. What do they look like

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to you?

JEFF: The cows? They look like cows.

ROBERT: Don't you think they look a little like tanks? Sherman tanks. Don't you think they look a little, off in the distance there in silhouette, like tanks? We have footage of tanks. I just keep jump cutting for half a second at a time to these shots of tanks. All the way through, just keep jump cutting to tanks, three, four frames a shot, they will be subliminally convinced that they're looking at tanks. ***They will be subliminally convinced!***

JEFF: Because you showed them tanks every once in a while, they're gonna think those cows are tanks? Who do you think your audience is?

ROBERT: Idiots, Jeff. I think the vast majority are lazy, stupid idiots who, I believe, can be convinced by a clever director with enough footage at his disposal that three cows are in fact Sherman tanks.

JEFF: Well, you're wrong. The only person who thinks those cows are anything but cows is you.

ROBERT: We are film makers and we don't lock ourselves into conventional notions and labels. We give ourselves the freedom to explore and communicate our own surroundings and we don't file the world around us into little shoe-boxes and label them black and white.

JEFF: Those are cows, Bobby. ***THEY LOOK LIKE COWS!*** They walk like cows! They eat like cows! They're cows! Accept that fact. I wouldn't lie to you about something like this. And I think they're the best thing in the movie.

ROBERT: *(Pause. quietly)* You're right. You're right. They're cows. There's really no way of getting around that. They're cows. They'll have to stay cows. So fine. Okay. There are three cows standing in the last shot of the picture. *(Pause)* What did I mean by that? What was I trying to say? I need to examine this. What are cows? What ***are*** cows? What do cows do? Cows give milk. Milk is life. Is milk life? No, not really. Milk is milk. But it's also life in a way. Sure. Milk. Mother's milk. The milk of life. *(Pause)* Young, disillusioned Marines ... *Young* disillusioned Marines . . . what? . . . Sucking the milk of life. . . the last drops of the milk of life, right? . . . Sunset? Endings? The Last Drops? *(He's got it)* Young disillusioned Marines sucking the last drops of life from cows . . . Because their mother's aren't there with them in Guam! *(Beat)*

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(REUBEN enters)

REUBEN: Those cows were a pain in the a**, huh? What the hell, we'll just matte 'em out when we cut it. Hell of a sight though. I swear, I almost *peed* my pants.

ROBERT: Matte' em out? . . . . *(With bravado)* Why would I want to matte out the cows? I rehearsed those cows, I auditioned over four-hundred cows. Those were my first choice. You gotta admit, the camera loves 'em. It's the whole statement of the picture . . . The cows.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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